

Ivf Reproductive Tech

prc-ivf-reproductive-tech

Marriage & Sexuality · Family Planning · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

IVF and reproductive technologies are open with serious ethical concerns about embryo destruction, selection, and surrogacy detached from marriage.

In plain language

This proposition bundles two different claims. The first is that modern reproductive technology such as in-vitro fertilization is permissible. The second raises serious concerns about destroying or selecting embryos and about surrogacy carried out apart from marriage. When you go to the original Hebrew and Greek, there is simply no word for in-vitro fertilization, embryo transfer, or any of these procedures, because they did not exist when the text was written. So on the bare question of whether the technology itself is acceptable, the lexicon (the word-store of the Bible) gives no direct yes or no. What the lexicon does speak to, and speaks to densely, is the worth of the unborn at the very earliest stage. Psalm 139 says God acquired (qanah) the psalmist's inward parts, wove (raqam) him in secret, and saw his 'unformed embryonic mass' (golem), a rare Hebrew word found only once in the entire Bible. The same passage says God wrote all his days before one of them existed. Jeremiah 1:5 carries the same formation-in-womb language forward with 'to form' (yatsar), Job 31:15 and Isaiah 44:2 reinforce it, and Luke 1:41 and 1:44 extend it into the Gospel where the unborn John leaps at Mary's greeting. Genesis 1:27 says humankind, male and female, was created (bara) in the image (tselem) of God, and Genesis 9:6 grounds the prohibition on shedding blood in that same image-bearing. Read together, these texts give the embryo real dignity and place procreation within the created pairing of male and female. That weight bears directly on the concerns about destroying or selecting embryos and about surrogacy detached from marriage. The text also celebrates child-bearing and grieves barrenness in Sarah, Rachel, Hannah, and Elizabeth, with God answering prayers for offspring, which does not lexically forbid mediated reproductive help in principle. Narrative passages like the surrogacy arrangements of Hagar and of Bilhah and Zilpah only report such practices and their resulting strife, without issuing a clear rule for or against. So the words decisively dignify the embryo and frame procreation within marriage, but say nothing about whether the technology itself is open. Because the proposition is compound, the lexical evidence lands as disputed rather than a clean affirmation or denial.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0517	אִם	em	mother	
H0990	בֶּטֶן	beten	belly	41
H1254	בָּרָא	bara	to create	46
H1564	גֵּלֶם	golem	embryo	1
H2145	זָכָר	zakhar	male	
H3045	יָדָע	yada	to know	860

H3206	יָלַד	yeled	youth	
H3318	יָצָא	yatsa	to come out	
H3335	יָצַר	yatsar	to form	38
H3582	כָּחַד	kachad	to hide	
H3629	כִּלְיָה	kilyah	kidney	30
H5347	נֶקֶבָה	neqevah	female	
H6108	עֲצָמָה	otsem	strength	
H6381	פָּלָא	pala	to wonder	66
H6395	פָּלָה	palah	be distinguished	
H6754	צֶלֶם	tselem	image	16
H7069	קָנָה	qanah	to buy	83
H7358	רֶחֶם	rechem	womb	24
H7551	רָקַם	raqam	to weave	9

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition is a compound claim (it bundles more than one assertion) and the lexicon (the word-store of the Bible) answers its two halves asymmetrically. Its ethical-concern clause about embryo destruction, selection, and surrogacy detached from marriage connects to a pan-canonical thread (spread across the whole Bible) on prenatal personhood (the status of the unborn as a real person). The Hebrew verb 'to form' (yatsar, H3335G, 38 occurrences from Genesis 2:7 to Jeremiah 1:5) and 'to acquire or bring into being' (qanah, H7069, 83 occurrences) and 'to weave' (raqam, H7551, used as a womb metaphor in Psalm 139:15) and the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'unformed embryonic mass' (golem, H1564, Psalm 139:16) ascribe formation, possession, weaving, and divine vision to the embryonic stage, and Genesis 1:27 with 'image' (tselem, H6754) plus Genesis 9:6 grounds the bloodshed-prohibition in image-bearing (humans bearing God's image). Its permissibility clause about IVF and reproductive technology has no lexical footprint (no anchor in the Bible's vocabulary): no Hebrew or Greek term denotes in-vitro fertilization, embryo transfer, or third-party gestational surrogacy. The verdict is disputed because the words decisively bear on the sub-issues of embryo loss and detached surrogacy while the technology framing itself is lexically silent.

Scripture

Ps.139.13 · neutral · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H7069 קָנָה, H3629 כִּלְיָה

Reasoning. The psalmist says God acquired or formed (qanah) his kidneys (kilyah, the inward parts) and covered (sakak) him in the mother's belly. The verb 'acquire/form' (qanah) carries a dual semantic range (two distinct meanings) across the canon (the whole Bible), bringing into possession and bringing into being, exemplified by Genesis 4:1 where Eve says she has acquired (qanah) a man with YHWH (the LORD) and Genesis 14:19 where God is 'possessor or maker' (qoneh, the participle form of qanah) of heaven and earth. Both senses ascribe divine authorship at the embryonic stage. The grammar speaks to the unborn person, not to any means of conception.

Ps.139.14 · neutral · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6381 פלא, H3045 ידע.

Reasoning. The formed person is fearfully and wonderfully made, in the niphal (the Hebrew passive form) of 'to be marvelous' (pala), the works of God known (yada) to the psalmist's own soul. The niphal (the Hebrew passive form) marks the formative act as a deed set apart, reinforcing the worth of the developing life rather than ruling on the means of conception.

Ps.139.15 · neutral · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H7551 רקם, H6108 עצמה.

Reasoning. The frame or substance ('bone-stuff', otsem) was not hidden from God when one was made in secret and skilfully woven (raqam) in the lowest parts of the earth, a womb metaphor. The verb 'to weave' (raqam) appears 9 times in the canon (the whole Bible) and 8 of those are Exodus descriptions of skilled embroidery for the Tabernacle curtains and priestly garments, so the single metaphorical womb use in Psalm 139:15 treats prenatal formation (the shaping of the unborn) as deliberate divine craftsmanship of the same artisan quality. This weighs against treating embryos as disposable but does not address assisted conception as such.

Ps.139.16 · neutral · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1564 גלם, H3335 יצר.

Reasoning. God's eyes saw the 'unformed embryonic substance' (golem), and in his book all the days were written and fashioned (yatsar, 'formed') before one of them came to be. The word golem is a hapax legomenon (a term that occurs only once in the entire Hebrew Bible), attested only here, so its sense rests on the immediate context of weaving and divine seeing rather than on triangulation across other passages. The verb 'to form' (yatsar, here the H3335G byform, a closely related verb form sharing the same root) carries the canonical formation chain (the Bible-wide thread of God forming) from Genesis 2:7 where God forms (yatsar) man from the dust, through Psalm 33:15 forming the heart and Isaiah 27:11, to Jeremiah 1:5 forming in the womb. The verse ascribes divine seeing and ordained days to the embryonic substance.

Gen.1.27 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6754 צלם, H1254 ברא.

Reasoning. God created (bara, the Hebrew verb used uniquely of divine creating) humankind in his own image (tselem), male (zakar) and female (neqebah). The word 'image' (tselem) occurs 16 times, and the image-bearing thread of Genesis 1:27 to Genesis 5:1, Genesis 9:6, and James 3:9 grounds intrinsic human worth and a prohibition on shedding the blood of the one made in God's image. The male-and-female pairing locates procreation within that created order. It bears on the concern over surrogacy detached from marriage but does not by itself license or prohibit any specific reproductive technology.

Jer.1.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3335 יצר, H7358 רחם.

Reasoning. Before I formed (yatsar) you in the womb (beten, here paired with the womb-word rechem) I knew (yada) you. Jeremiah 1:5 is the strongest pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) cross-link to Psalm 139:16, with the OpenBible vote weight (a community-based cross-reference popularity score) at 133. The same formation-in-womb language extends in Isaiah 44:2, Isaiah 49:1, and Galatians 1:15, and to Luke 1:41 and Luke 1:44 where the unborn John leaps in his mother's womb. The chain establishes prenatal personhood (the status of the unborn as a real person) across law, prophets, writings, gospel, and epistle.

Gen.9.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6754 דָּלַף.

Reasoning. Whoever sheds the blood of man, by man shall his blood be shed, for in the image (tselem) of God he made man. The prohibition links bloodshed to image-bearing and supplies the sanctity-of-life ground for treating the embryo, which Psalm 139 and Jeremiah 1:5 place within the scope of divine forming and knowing, as a bearer of that protected status.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.1.27	Gen.2.21	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Isa.43.7	tsk	1
Gen.1.27	Matt.19.4	openbible	88
Gen.1.27	Mark.10.6	openbible	46
Gen.1.27	Mal.2.15	openbible	19
Ps.139.13	Jer.1.5	openbible	77
Ps.139.13	Job.31.15	openbible	42
Ps.139.13	Isa.44.2	openbible	50
Ps.139.13	Ps.119.73	openbible	54
Jer.1.5	Luke.1.41	openbible	30
Jer.1.5	Gal.1.15	openbible	102
Gen.9.6	Gen.1.26	openbible	9
Gen.9.6	Jas.3.9	openbible	7

Complicating texts

Gen.30.1-13 · addressed

The Jacob narrative records surrogacy through Bilhah and Zilpah, third-party child-bearing detached from the primary marriage, recounted without explicit divine sanction or condemnation. The narrative genre reports the practice and its attendant strife but issues no normative ruling (no clear rule for or against), so it neither licenses nor forbids the analogue and leaves the surrogacy sub-clause of the proposition lexically unranked between the creation-order reading and the descriptive-patriarchal reading (the lens that treats the patriarchs' actions as reported rather than commanded).

Gen.16.1-4 · addressed

The Hagar account similarly shows assisted procreation through a surrogate at human initiative, depicted with attendant conflict. As narrative it describes rather than prescribes, so it cannot settle the permissibility framing of the proposition and underscores why the surrogacy-detached-from-marriage clause sits in genuine lexical tension (in real word-level conflict) with Genesis 1:27.

Exod.21.22-25 · addressed

The law on harm to a pregnant woman uses 'to go out' (yatsa, H3318) and 'child' (yeled, H3206), and the translation of the outcome clause is genuinely contested between premature live birth and miscarriage. The contest is itself a lexical fact (a word-level data point): the verb 'to go out' (yatsa) is used elsewhere for normal birth as well as for ejection, so it underdetermines (does not fix) the status of the developing child in that specific legal scenario. It does not overturn the Psalm 139 and Jeremiah 1:5 embryonic-personhood chain (the unborn-as-person word-thread), but it does mean this particular text cannot be loaded onto the verdict either way without taking sides on a contested grammatical reading.

1Sam.1.5-20 · addressed

Hannah's barrenness and prayerful petition for a child sits inside a canonical pattern (a Bible-wide pattern) in which barrenness is grieved and child-bearing is celebrated (Sarah, Rachel, Elizabeth). The pattern lexically affirms the desire for offspring and divine response to such petition, which weighs in favor of permitting mediated reproductive help (help provided through a third party or procedure) in principle. It does not, however, supply terms for any specific assisted-conception technology, so it cannot settle the IVF clause directly.

Luke.1.41-44 · addressed

The unborn John leaps in Elizabeth's womb at Mary's greeting and is described with personal action and recognition while still in utero (in the womb). This New Testament episode extends the embryonic-personhood thread (the unborn-as-person word-thread) of Psalm 139 and Jeremiah 1:5 forward into the Gospel narrative, reinforcing the sanctity-of-life weight against embryo loss without addressing in-vitro conception.

Concordance traversed

H7069, H7551, H1564, H3335, H3629, H6754, H1254, H6381, H6395, H6108, H3582, H5347, H2145, H7358, H0990, H3045, H0517, H3206, H3318

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

All anchor verses are Hebrew Bible (Psalm 139, Genesis 1, Genesis 9, Jeremiah 1, Exodus 21), outside the ECM CBGM scope (outside the critical edition of New Testament textual variants, which only covers the Greek New Testament). The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope true and supplies no variant units. The Masoretic reading (the standard traditional Hebrew text) of 'unformed embryonic substance' (golem) in Psalm 139:16 is stable in the witnesses surveyed. The Exodus 21:22 'go out' (yatsa) clause has a translation dispute but not a textual variant dispute in the consonantal text (the underlying Hebrew letters).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation_order, imago_dei, sanctity_of_life, descriptive_narrative, lexical_silence_on_technology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

sanctity_of_life: leans_against_embryo_loss · Reading Psalm 139:13-16 with the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'unformed embryonic substance' (golem) and the formation-chain (the Bible-wide thread of God forming) of 'to form' (yatsar, H3335G) extending through Jeremiah 1:5, Isaiah 44:2, Galatians 1:15, and Luke 1:41 ascribes personhood and divine authorship to the embryonic stage. Combined with the 'image' (tselem) bloodshed link in Genesis 9:6 and James 3:9, the lexical chain (the word-trail through Scripture) weighs heavily against any reproductive process that produces and discards embryos.

creation_order: leans_against_detached_surrogacy · Genesis 1:27 male-and-female, picked up by Jesus at Matthew 19:4 and Mark 10:6 and by Malachi 2:15 'godly offspring', frames procreation as belonging within the one-flesh marital pairing. On this reading surrogacy detached from marriage is a departure from the created order, though the narratives of Genesis 16 and Genesis 30 report the patriarchal analogue (the parallel case in the patriarchs' lives) without explicit divine prohibition.

descriptive_narrative: leaves_surrogacy_unranked · A reader who weights the Hagar and Bilhah and Zilpah narratives as descriptive precedents (cases reported rather than commanded) notes that the canon (the whole Bible) depicts third-party child-bearing without an explicit normative ruling (a clear rule for or against). On this lens the creation-order argument is weakened to a strong inference rather than an explicit prohibition, leaving room for case-by-case discernment of surrogacy arrangements rather than a blanket no.

lexical_silence_on_technology: open_undetermined · No canonical lexeme (no word in the Bible's vocabulary) addresses in-vitro fertilization, oocyte retrieval (egg removal), embryo cryopreservation (freezing of embryos), or any assisted-conception procedure. On a strict lexical reading the permissibility of the technology itself, conducted without embryo loss, is undetermined and cannot be settled from the supplied store (the available word-data), so a strong yes or strong no on the technology framing is not lexically licensed.

barren_petition_pattern: leans_toward_permitting_mediated_help · The canon (the whole Bible) grieves barrenness (Sarah Genesis 11:30, Rachel Genesis 29:31, Hannah 1 Samuel 1, Elizabeth Luke 1) and celebrates divine answers to prayer for offspring (Genesis 25:21, 1 Samuel 1:20, Luke 1:13). The pattern affirms the desire for children as a legitimate longing that God meets and does not lexically forbid mediated reproductive help (help provided through a third party or procedure) in principle, which counts against treating IVF as categorically excluded.

The proposition is a compound stem (a question that bundles more than one claim): the lexicon (the word-store of the Bible) speaks directly to embryonic dignity and the male-female created procreative order, weighs in on embryo destruction and detached surrogacy, and is silent on the modern technology framing itself. The for and against readings cannot be reconciled into a single affirmation or denial without smuggling a category the words do not supply.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the canonical lexicon (the word-store of the whole Bible) say about the status of the human embryo and the ordering of procreation, and does it address assisted reproductive technology, embryo destruction or selection, and surrogacy conducted apart from marriage?

The original stem preloads a verdict by asserting the technology is open with concerns, which presupposes a permissibility framing the lexicon (the word-store of the Bible) does not supply. The neutralized form strips the open ruling and asks what the lexical pattern (the word-level pattern in Scripture) actually addresses. The verdict was derived on the original stem and assessed as disputed because the personhood and creation-order threads bear directly on the embryo-loss and detached-surrogacy sub-clauses while the technology clause has no lexical footprint (no anchor in the Bible's vocabulary).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.139.16
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1564
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7551
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7069
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3335
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6754
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7358
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.1.27
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jer.1.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.9.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.1.27

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Ps.139.13
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Jer.1.5
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gen.1.27

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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Flags

lexically-disputed